ERA 16

The Roaring Twenties

1920 – 1929

Prosperity · the automobile · mass culture · the Jazz Age

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did new technology, wealth, and mass culture transform American life in the 1920s?

KEY TERMS

Return to normalcy · the Model T · installment buying · mass media · the Harlem Renaissance

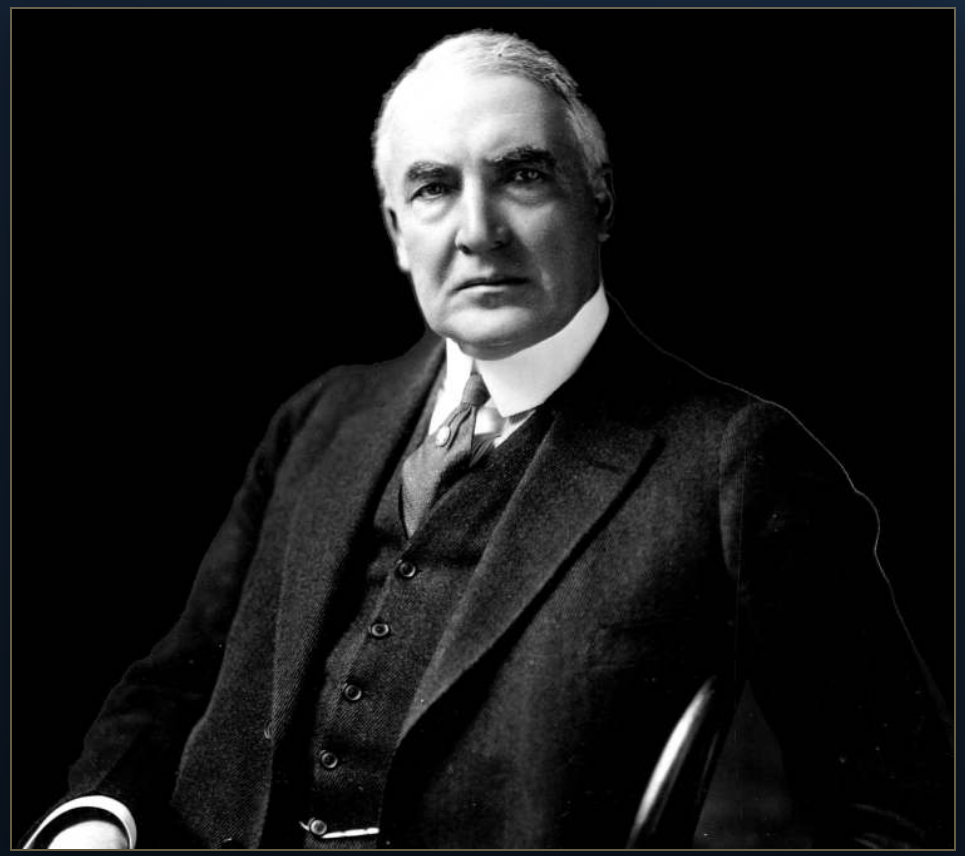
ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 7.7 · AMSCO Ch. 7.7

PROSPERITY AND MODERN LIFE

The New Era

Return to Normalcy



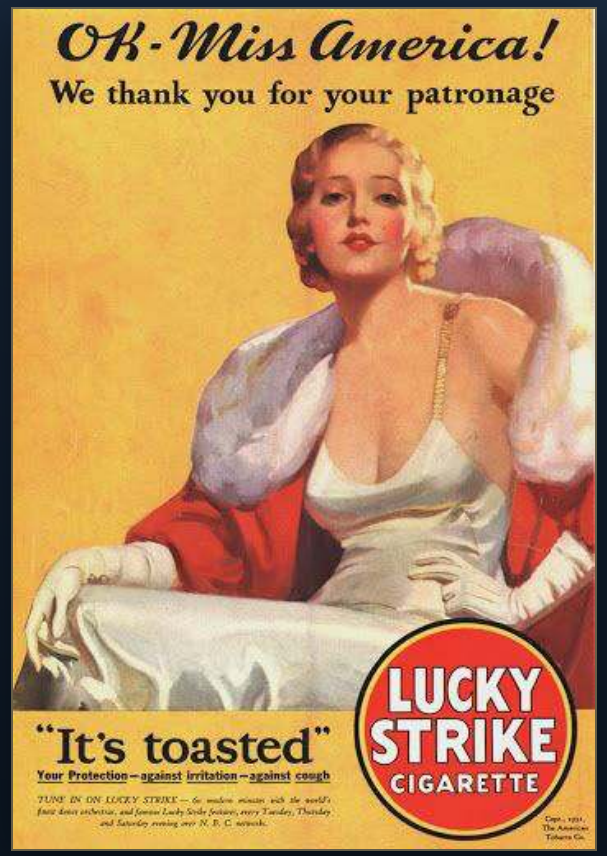
- Republicans **Harding**, **Coolidge**, and **Hoover** championed **pro-business** government.
- 'The business of America is business.'
- Low taxes and light regulation fueled a booming economy.

The Automobile Revolution

- **Henry Ford's assembly line** made the **Model T** affordable—just $290 by 1924.
- By 1929 there was roughly one car for every five Americans.
- The auto boom drove steel, rubber, oil, roads, and suburbs.



A Consumer Culture



- A flood of new goods—radios, refrigerators, vacuums—filled American homes.
- The **installment plan** let families 'buy now, pay later' on **credit**.
- A booming **advertising** industry taught Americans to want more.

SECTION

A Mass Culture

The Silver Screen & the Airwaves

- Movies became the nation's favorite entertainment—**Charlie Chaplin** and the first 'talkie,' ***The Jazz Singer*** (1927).
- **Radio** broadcasting linked the country in real time.
- For the first time, Americans everywhere shared the same **mass media**.



The New Woman & the Flapper



- The **flapper** symbolized a new, more independent woman.
- Shorter skirts, bobbed hair, jazz, and dance halls shocked traditionalists.
- The 19th Amendment and city life opened new freedoms.

The Jazz Age & the Harlem Renaissance

- **Jazz**—led by artists like **Louis Armstrong**—became the sound of the decade.
- The **Great Migration** fed a Black cultural flowering in New York: the **Harlem Renaissance**.
- Writers like **Langston Hughes** and leaders like **Marcus Garvey** gave voice to Black pride.



KEY TAKEAWAYS

The Roaring Twenties

1. Pro-business government and the **automobile** powered a decade of **prosperity** and **mass production**.
2. **Advertising**, **installment credit**, and new appliances built a modern **consumer culture**.
3. **Movies**, **radio**, the **flapper**, and the **Harlem Renaissance** created a vibrant new national culture.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The Roaring Twenties

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how the **automobile** and **mass production** reshaped the American economy and society.

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did **mass media** create a shared national culture in the 1920s?

CONTEXTUALIZATION

How did the **Harlem Renaissance** reflect both the promise and the limits of the New Era?

Up next — **Class 44: A Nation Divided** (nativism, the Klan, Scopes & Prohibition)